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1. Play outside

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Like most kids then, my dad spent his days when not in school outside playing with his older brother and the neighborhood kids. He did have to forgo riding on his tricycle after it was repossessed, but apparently found other things to do.

Outside play is generally free or cheap, even if it means driving to the playground, and it's not just an activity for kids. When I operated on a very limited budget in a small town right out of college, I spent much of my leisure time outside, usually hiking in the nearby mountains with friends.

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2. Write letters

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Writing letters can be a form of entertainment or pastime, and a way to record one's history; my mother has letters from her mom, and reading them makes me feel as if she is right next to me, sharing her story.

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3. Keep your government job

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My mother-in-law's dad was a mail carrier with the United States Postal Service (a government job) and so had a reliable source of income, unlike many of their neighbors. Her family

was able to help others in their small, rural community.

I am sure that there are many exciting and well-paying government jobs, but a key element of their attractiveness is stability. There is often a trade-off between the opportunity for higher pay in a risky environment and lower wages in a safer arena (consider looking for a new job if you have a low-paying position in a volatile environment).

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4. Grow food

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My grandmother raised chickens in her tiny, urban backyard; when she was ready to fix dinner, she caught a chicken and cooked it. My mother-in-law's parents had a garden on land they owned; everyone was encouraged to grow produce in order to feed themselves, and sell the excess to neighbors, as the reliability of food distribution was uncertain.

The get-closer-to-your-food movement has been gaining momentum, though many never abandoned this concept. My in-laws now have a farm on which they grow corn, potatoes, peppers, and more. My parents have always had tomato plants, and my dad is an expert farmers' market shopper, always investigating and committing to memory who is a farmer and who is a reseller only, who has the best produce and who doesn't.